

30 Minutes Expert Are you Gaim?

Tired of shuffling between Yahoo!, MSN and AOL? Use multi-network instant messengers instead

If you're a chronic chatter (and who isn't!), with your friends on Yahoo!, colleagues on MSN and friendly strangers on ICQ, consider using a multi-network messengers. As the name suggests, these messengers allow you to log into multiple accounts at the same time using a single IM. The most popular ones are Gaim and Trillian. Gaim supports all the popular networks—MSN, Yahoo!, IRC, AOL, Jabber, Gadu-Gadu and Zephyr. And did we mention it's free? Though Microsoft had announced discontinuance of support for third-party messengers post 15 October 2003, Gaim still works fine with MSN.

Gaim 0.74, the latest version, can be obtained from <http://gaim.sourceforge.net>. It's compatible with both Linux and Windows, and takes about 11 MB of disk space. When the program is executed, the login screen will be shown. Since it's your first time, the login screen will be empty; go to **Accounts > Add** to create new accounts. Enter the details of the messenger account you want to add. In 'Protocol' select the Network type (Yahoo!, MSN, or IRC); in the Screenname and password fields, enter your username and password. The other fields are self explanatory, and aren't mandatory. Repeat the same steps for every account. All the accounts created will be shown in the Accounts window, along with two checkboxes—one for Online and other for Auto-login. Select the Online checkbox to log in to that account, and check the Auto-login box if you want to log into that



The Protocol, Screenname and Password are mandatory when entering the details of an account

account every time Gaim is launched.

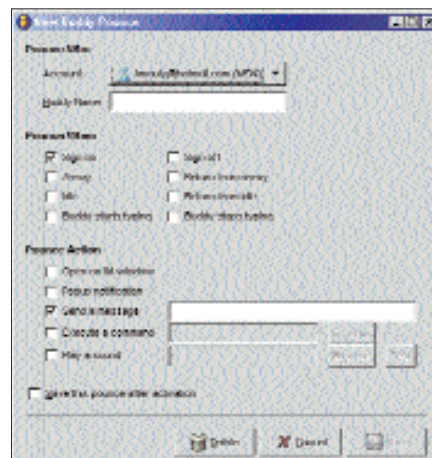
After logging into the accounts, you will be shown a buddy list, just like in other IMs. Click on Buddies in the menu bar to perform actions such as adding a buddy, creating a group, blocking a buddy, etc. Other functions are performed just as in any other client—double-click on a friend to start a conversation. Gaim has a tabbed interface in the message window, so you chat with many buddies simultaneously using a single window. To change the status message, go to **Tools > Away** and select the account for which you want to change the status, and then select the new status from the cascading menu. To set a customised Away message go to **Tools > Away > New Away Message**. In the window that appears, enter a title for the away message in the 'Away Title field', enter the actual away message in the textbox below the title field. Note that the customised away message will only be displayed in networks that support them such as Yahoo!.

If you are using the messenger from your office, or if your system is behind a firewall, you will have to enter the proxy server settings—get this from your system administrator. To enter the proxy details, go to the Preferences by pressing **[Ctrl] + [P]**. In the left pane, select Proxy and enter the details. There are other settings in the Preferences that you can tinker with, such as sound alerts, fonts, etc.

An important setting is Plugins—in the left pane select Plugins; a list of plugins available will be shown. Select the checkbox next to each entry to load the corresponding plugin. The two notable ones are 'Text replacement' and 'History'. Using Text replacement, you can create abbreviations for commonly used expressions while chatting. For example, you can configure 'r u thr' to be displayed as 'Are you there?'. When you start a new conversation, the History plugin will insert the last conversation into the current one. This makes it easier for you to continue from where you left off.

Another useful feature is Buddy

Pounce, which allows you to specify a predefined action, such as send a message, play a sound, which is performed when a buddy logs on or off, etc. To enter a new Buddy Pounce, go to **Tools > Buddy Pounce > New Buddy Pounce**. In the window that pops up, select the account for which the Buddy Pounce has to be specified. Then enter the e-mail address of the friend for whom the Pounce is intended. In the 'Pounce when' section, select the action that the buddy has to perform such as Log in, Return from idle, and in 'Pounce action', specify the action you want performed. To repeat the Pounce, tick-mark the 'Save this pounce after activation' checkbox. Thus, using Buddy Pounce you can configure Gaim to send a message every time a specified friend logs in.



Enable the 'Save pounce after activation' to repeat a pounce action

However, Gaim isn't exactly the fabled bed of roses; there are some irritants. Incidentally, the two instances of Gaim that we ran in Windows 98 made the entire OS crash, but it didn't do that with Windows XP. Also, sometimes the menus and tool tips don't disappear even after the Gaim window is closed. Overlooking these hindrances, Gaim is quite a practical utility for managing your conversations. ■

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